Title Slide: Cultural Differences between the USA and Austria

Warmup

1. Every student will go around the room and say something they think is true about American culture.

The Pledge of Allegiance

Claude: As first slide, insert text here of the pledge of allegiance and a picture of the American flag. I will walk the students through doing it to see what it feels like

Next slide:

1. Reflection: What did that feel like? Do you think this is still practiced in schools? What time period do you think this is from?

Next slide: History behind the Pledge

1. Written in 1885 by Captain George Thatcher Balch, a Union army officer in the Civil War
2. Flag Day, 1954: President Eisenhower adds "under God"

Claude: feel free to insert any other basic historical facts about the Pledge Next slide: What does this show about American culture?

1. Loyalty and patriotism
2. Unity?

Next slide: Legal challenges

1. Supreme Court in West Virginia State Board of Education v. Barnette (1943) rules that recitation of the Pledge cannot be compulsory

Claude: any other relevant info

Title slide:

1. Think: What part of American culture/law might lead the Supreme Court to this decision?

Separation between Chruch and State

Text Analysis: Thomas Jefferson, *Letter to Danbury Baptist Association*, 1802 "Believing with you that religion is a matter which lies solely between Man & his God, that he owes account to none other for his faith or his worship, that the legitimate powers of government reach actions only, & not opinions, I contemplate with sovereign reverence that act of the whole American people which declared that their legislature should "make no law respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof," thus building a wall of separation between Church & State. Adhering to this expression of the supreme will of the nation in behalf of the rights of conscience, I shall see with sincere satisfaction the progress of those sentiments which tend to restore to man all his natural rights, convinced he has no natural right in opposition to his social duties."

Next slide: How does this change American culture? Claude: List instances of Austrian lack of church/state separation that would be illegal in the US

1. Shops closed on Sundays
2.

Drinking Culture

1. Record low of Americans drink alcohol: Gallup 54% of the population (2026)
2. Austrian percentage: 90% (Narconon Europe)

Think: Why might this be?

Possible Explanations:

1. Increased Cannabis Usage
    1. 24 U.S. States have legalized cannabis for recreational use.
    2. Gallup: 17% of U.S. adults consume marijuana
    3. EUDA: 6.3% of Austrian adults
2. Alcohol is seen as unhealthier in the States
    1. Text Analysis: Bernhard Maisch, “Alcohol consumption—none is better than a little”, Herz

    “For several decades, epidemiological studies suggested that drinking alcohol in moderate quantities was beneficial. This was referred to as the “French paradox,” which described differences in mortality between France and Finland mainly, but also other countries, that were found in epidemiological studies. The difference in the levels of alcohol consumption was found to explain the differences in mortality in view of the otherwise similar risk factors. When alcoholic drinks per day were plotted against all-cause mortality this led to a J-shaped curve. This finding represented a window of benefit for moderate alcohol consumption. However, the recent publication by Zhao et al. in 2023 revisited the relationship between the quantity of alcohol consumed and mortality risk and led to a paradigm change, which has influenced not only the recommendations of Canada’s Guidance on Alcohol and Health but also the recommendations and guidelines of major health organizations: “No alcohol is better than a little.” The J-shaped curve as an explanation of the French paradox became a linear relationship between the amount of alcohol consumption and the increasing mortality from tumors and cardiovascular diseases. The renewed review of several control groups in previous epidemiological studies revealed a recruitment error due to the inclusion of abstinent ex-drinkers. Taking this bias into account, the alcohol-friendly view of small amounts of alcohol being cardioprotective had to be revised. The combined misuse of alcohol and other risk factors for carcinogenesis and heart diseases still needs further attention. The misuse of both alcohol and cocaine led to the conclusion that when the two risky substances are consumed together, it is even more detrimental than the mere sum of the two.”

    1. USA: “People who do not drink should not start drinking for any reason.”
    2. Austria: 24g per day (600 mL beer)

Living to Work and Working to Live

First slide: overview

1. Average paid time off (PTO) in the US is around 10-15 days a year
2. Austria: minimum of 5 weeks (25 days)
3. US work hours: 1765/year
4. Austrian work hours: 1611/year
5. Footnote: can you guess the leat and most countries? (germany + sudan)

Maybe split into next slide:

1. US average wages: 86,977$
2. Austria: 78,301$
3. US GDP per capita: 95,212$
4. Austrian GDP per capita: 61,080$

989/3248 billionaires in the world are American.

Think: What does this indicate about American/Austrian working cultures?

Activity: Spectrum Game

Claude: students will be shown a series of statements, and they must arrange themselves in the room based on how much they agree or disagree. Please put each prompt on its own slide.

1. I think a culture of social drinking is good.
2. The government should not express any religious tendencies.
3. Shops being closed on Sunday is a good thing, regardless of one's religion.
4. It is important to be loyal to one's country.
5. Work should be the main source of fulfilment in one's life.